

most archers, it is at best a stepping stone to recurve or compound archery — and at worst, a dead end.

Traditional look but recent origin

Unlike the sleek, high-tech metal and carbon-fibre recurve and compound bows used in global competitions such as the World Cups, continental tournaments, and the Olympics, the Indian bow appears rudimentary. It consists of two laminated bamboo limbs slotted into a hardwood grip and secured with metal screws.

Indian bow team gold medallist Ravi Malik of Haryana, who won men's team gold, appreciates its all-wood construction. "It's like the bow that Ram and Lakshman, and the warriors of the Mahabharata, used. This is part of our culture," says the 25-year-old, who has a sticker reading Jai Shri Shyam on his bow's grip.

However, despite its traditional aesthetic, the Indian bow is a relatively recent invention. Also called the Manipur bow, its origins date back to 1985, when Manipuri coach Chaoba Sharma — brother of Basanti Devi, the State's first international archer — designed it.

"Chaoba started an archery club in Manipur in the 1980s. There was a lot of interest in the sport, but recurve bows were too expensive," explains Premkumar Sharma, manager of the Manipur team. "After much trial and error, he attempted to replicate a recurve bow using bamboo. He made the first Indian bow in 1985 and even received a governor's award for his innovation. His aim was to create an affordable alternative. Gradually, it gained popularity, first in the Northeast, then Bengal, and eventually at the national level in the early 1990s."

Labour-intensive process

The process of making the Indian bow, which stands six feet tall, has changed little since the 1980s. "You need a very specific type of bamboo," says Premkumar. "The stem must be at least six years old and can only be harvested in November or December. If harvested at other



Making the transition: At the National Games, four-time Olympian Deepika Kumari signed an application form for 14-year-old Madho Birua, Jharkhand's youngest archery medallist at this National Games, to receive his first recurve bow. JONATHAN SELVARAJ

times, weevils (a type of beetle) could infest it, causing the bow to snap. After harvesting, the bamboo must be soaked in water for a month and then smoked for another six months. Only then is it ready to be shaped into limbs."

The wooden grip, into which the bamboo limbs are slotted, is made from a dense hardwood sourced from Myanmar. The arrows are crafted from younger bamboo, typically less than a year old. "The bamboo shoots come from the Kouburu Hills in Manipur," Premkumar explains. "They're usually not completely straight, so after harvesting, they are heated over a flame and manually straightened." The only non-natural components are the plastic fletches

at one end of the arrows and the metal arrowheads at the other.

Cost vs performance

The primary advantage of the Indian bow is its affordability. Outfitting an archer with an Indian bow and a set of arrows costs around Rs 10,000, whereas a good-quality recurve bow costs nearly Rs 4 lakh. "Most archers come from modest backgrounds. If you're just starting, investing in an expensive bow doesn't make sense. In Haryana, for every archer using a recurve bow, there must be ten using the Indian bow," says Haryana coach Manjeet Malik, who trains archers across all three disciplines — recurve, compound, and Indian bow.

However, the low cost comes with